

ChurchManager User Guide

Version 0.2.0-dev

For congregations using ChurchManager

ChurchManager brings worship planning, people and family records, attendance, reports, communications, and fund accounting into one congregation-owned application. This guide explains the ordinary tasks a user performs.

Technical installation and development procedures are maintained separately.

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1. Getting started

Installing ChurchManager

The ChurchManager Setup wizard checks the computer first, then collects the local database connection, congregation name, first Master Administrator, and optional catalog choices. Its review page never displays a password. The temporary Master Administrator password must be changed at first login.

During development the wizard opens in **preview mode**, which validates the complete plan without creating a database or changing saved credentials.

Sign in

Start ChurchManager from its Windows shortcut. Enter the user name and password provided by the congregation administrator. A temporary password must be changed when requested. Each person should use an individual account; accounts must not be shared.

The title bar clearly identifies a test database. Work entered in TEST MODE is not production congregation data.

Moving around

The main menu is organized by task. Select a blue item to open it. Close a task window to return to the main menu. Lists generally support double-clicking a row to open or edit the selected item. Buttons that are unavailable are disabled until the required selection is made.

Saving work

Use the screen's Save, Update, or Save Service control before closing. If a screen reports unsaved changes, choose whether to save or discard them. Red rows or red text identify information that still needs attention.

2. The main menu

Service Planning

- **Worship Services** creates and completes a service plan and its weekly

Order of Service.

- **Weekly Bulletin Order** reviews the outline prepared for a particular service.
- **Service Participants** assigns people to the positions required for a service.
- **Notify Participants** prepares participant messages.
- **Weekly Prayers** and **Weekly Announcements** show material scheduled for the selected week.
- **Prepare Bulletin Order** produces an outline suitable for copying into a bulletin document.

Worship Resources

This group maintains sermons, local lectionaries, bulletin-order templates, prayers, announcements, hymnals, hymns, participants, positions, scheduling patterns, and preparation checklists. Installed package records are protected; make congregation-owned records or customized templates when changes are needed.

People and Congregation

This group contains church information, people, families, attendance, projects, tasks, documents, and the journal.

Reports and Design

Use **Reports** to run approved reports. Authorized users may use **Report Designer** and **Screen Designer** to create congregation-specific layouts. Starter layouts remain available for recovery.

ChurchManager Settings

Authorized administrators maintain configuration, choices, users, email, catalog packages, backups, and support diagnostics here.

3. People and congregation records

Church information

Enter the congregation's name, address, contact information, report logo, primary hymnal, and default lectionary. The selected hymnal and lectionary guide the choices offered in worship planning.

People

Create one person record for each member or other person the congregation needs to track. A person may have a photograph and may be linked to a family. Telephone numbers are stored as digits and formatted for display. Respect every unlisted-contact setting; unlisted contact information is excluded from public directory output.

Families

Family records group people for directories and household communication. A family may have its own photograph and address information. Confirm family membership before generating a directory.

Users are separate from people

A ChurchManager user may optionally be linked to a person record, but the two records serve different purposes. Not every member needs a user account, and a user does not have to be a congregation member.

4. Worship planning

Create a worship service

1. Open **Worship Services** and create a new service.
2. Enter the service date, time, location, and congregation.
3. Select an Order of Service template.
4. Select a Proper when one applies. The Proper supplies the printable liturgical title, color, reading citations, and hymn suggestions.
5. Review the service outline on the left and the service details on the right.
6. Fill every required hymn or reading line and resolve red warnings.
7. Assign participants and review the Preparation Checklist.
8. Save the service.

Creating a worship service also creates its attendance event. The saved weekly Order of Service is a service snapshot; later changes to the source template do not rewrite the saved service.

Order of Service templates

Templates store outline metadata only. They do not contain complete liturgical texts, prayers, psalms, lyrics, music, or publisher artwork. Create an editable custom template from a starter or create one from scratch. Required participant positions may be attached to a template and carried into a new service.

Hymns

Select a hymn line before using **Select Hymn**. The hymn picker searches and sorts the congregation's installed hymnal entries. A selected hymn displays its title as the weekly value and its hymnal number as the reference. Select stanzas when needed. Duplicate hymn selections are always flagged, including duplicates chosen manually.

For Lutheran Service Book references, pages in the service section use the form LSB p. 151; printed hymns use the form LSB 331. Psalms are citations, not LSB page references.

Readings, colors, and titles

ChurchManager stores biblical citations, not Scripture text. A service planner may override a reading in the weekly outline. The printable liturgical title comes from the Proper. A service-specific color override updates the color block on the planning screen and planning report.

Preparation checklist

The checklist is a planning reminder, not a hard closing system. Items may be Done, Not Done, or Not Needed. One-time tasks may be added to a service. The summary reports checklist progress, required participant coverage, and hymn completion. Marking the whole checklist complete records the planner's judgment even when an exception is intentional.

5. Attendance

Open **Attendance** and choose an event. Worship services normally create their attendance events automatically. Members appear first, followed by visitors. Visitors may be counted without creating person records. Record communion only when it was offered and the information is appropriate to maintain.

Available reports include event listings, weekly attendance, year-to-date totals, individual history, member follow-up, and a pastor's comparison report. The follow-up report can flag members after a chosen number of consecutive missed weeks.

6. Prayers, announcements, and participant notices

Prayers and announcements use categories maintained in Choices. Their natural language schedules may describe patterns such as Every Sunday, First and Third Sunday of the month, or an approved fixed annual date. Scheduling is week-based so material may apply to Sunday, Wednesday, or another service in the same ministry week. Unsupported or ambiguous expressions are rejected.

Use the weekly preview before preparing bulletin material. Participant notices use the congregation's configured email service. TEST MODE never sends external email.

7. Reports and layout customization

Select a report, supply its enabled parameters, and choose **Run Report**. ChurchManager creates a PDF using a protected report dataset. A customized layout is shown in blue; when no customization exists, ChurchManager uses the starter layout.

Authorized users may open the Report Designer, create a customization from a starter, move and resize controls, preview the PDF, validate the definition, and restore the starter. Report definitions control presentation only; they do not bypass report permissions or expose unapproved database fields.

8. Fund accounting

Initial setup

Complete Accounting Setup, the chart of accounts, funds and restrictions, functional classifications, fiscal years and periods, bank accounts, and payees before entering live transactions.

Daily work

1. Create a balanced draft in **Transaction Entry**.
2. Review it and mark it ready.
3. Approve it under the congregation's approval policy.
4. Post it. Posting makes the accounting entry permanent.
5. Use a reversing transaction to correct a posted entry.

Small congregations may enable the audited solo-approval policy. When used, the override and its reason remain in the audit history.

Bank work and reconciliation

Bank File Import previews and stages a bank CSV; it does not post transactions. Match imported lines carefully, complete the reconciliation, and review the reconciliation report before closing the period.

Budgets and period end

Budgets may use general accounts alone or include detailed line items. Review Budget to Actual and the Close Checklist before period or year-end processing. Year-End Close is controlled and auditable; make a verified backup first.

9. Users, email, backup, and recovery

Users and roles

Administrators create individual accounts and assign only the permissions each user needs. A new account may be linked to a person and may receive a temporary password notice after outgoing email has been configured. Disable accounts that should no longer sign in instead of reusing them.

Email

Configure the congregation's SMTP provider under **Email Settings** and test the connection. Credentials are protected locally and are not written into reports, logs, or database backups. TEST MODE suppresses delivery.

Backup

Use **Database Backup** regularly and before migrations, restore operations, year-end close, or major catalog changes. The default backup folder may be changed. An optional automatic backup can run when ChurchManager exits.

Restore

Restore replaces the active database with the selected backup. Read every warning, verify the database name shown, and allow the operation to finish. ChurchManager must restart after a successful restore because its previous database connections were closed.

10. Getting help

Select **Help - User Guide** on the main menu to open this document. If an unexpected error occurs, note what you were doing and open **Support and Diagnostics**. Create the privacy-safe support package and give that package to the person supporting ChurchManager. Do not send database passwords.

The application version appears in the ChurchManager title bar. Include that version when requesting help.

ChurchManager is open-source congregation software. This guide describes the 0.2.0-dev development release and will be revised as beta testing identifies additional instructions or screenshots that are needed.